Petite Rouge:

A Cajun Red Riding Hood

By Mike Artell

**See the end of this selection for pronunciation guide and a link to the author reading the story in the Cajun dialect. The more you play up the dialect, the more humor you will pull from this selection!*

Back in de swamp
where dat Spanish moss grow,
I heard me a story
from long time ago.

In a little ol' house
dat been built outta wood,
live a girl people call
Petite Rouge Riding Hood.

INTRODUCTION

Petite Rouge: A Cajun Red Riding Hood by Mike Artell

One day, when her grand-mere
come down wit' de flu,
Petite Rouge mama tol' her
what she got to do.

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"Take her dis gumbo
an' t'ree or two sweater.
An' some uh dis boudin
gone make her feel better.

"You can take de pirogue
wit' dat big long push pole,
den dere's jus' one mo' t'ing
dat you need to be tol'.

"Don' stop in de swamp!
Don' you stop on de way!
'Cause de swamp's fulla gators,
Cher! Dat's where dey stay!

"So you take dat cat
in de pirogue wit' you.
An' bring youself home
jus' as soon as you t'roo."

Petite Rouge take dat food,
an' her cat TeJean too,
den jump in dat pirogue
like she tol' to do.

Mama wave adieu
an', TeJean, he wave back,

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as he float t'roo de swamp
where de water look black.

Dey don' be gone long
when dey see by a stomp,
a big, long, green log
dat got plenty a' bomp.

Dat log, it come close
to de pirogue and say,
"Now what you two doin' out here. . .
si'l vous plait?"

It was Claude, dat ol' gator.
Petite Rouge gotta honch
dat ol' Claude t'ink in' he'd
like to have her fo' lonch.

"We takin' dis food to mah
gran –mere's," she say.
"An' I got me dis pole,
so you git out de way!"

"Pardon, mad'moiselle,
I don' mean to be rude.
I jus' t'inkin' dat maybe
you share some you food.

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"A taste a' dat boudin
or shrimp etouffee.
Dat's all dat I want,
den I'll git out de way."

Petite Rouge raise dat pole
way up high in de air,
an' she look at ol' Claude,
an' she give him a stare.

"I'm countin' to t'ree,
an' if you still dere,
dis pole gonna hit you
where you part you hair."

An' when she say "One,"
Ol' Claude back out de way.
He know dat de girl
sho' 'nuff mean what she say.

Den li'l Petite Rouge
push dat pirogue ag'in.
An' ol' Claude close his eyes.
An' ol' Claude start to grin.

"I got an idea
an' I know what to do.

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I'll get me dat food
an' dat li'l girl too!"

Dat gator swim fast,
an' den quick as dem mouse,
he up on de porch of
Grand-mere's ol' house.

He open de door and
den stick in his head.
An' den he see Grand-mere
asleep in de bed.

He try to tiptoe
so she don' hear no sound,
but his tail bomp de shelf
an' two cup fall down.

When dey hit de floor (CRASH!),
it break bot' dem cup.
An' Grand-mere, she hear it.
An' Grand-mere wake up . . .

"Sacre!" she exclaim.
"I know dis ain't right!"
Den she run in de closet
an' lock dat door tight!

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"Ha! Ha!" ol' Claude laugh.
"You can hide; dat's okay.
In fac', it's mo' better
wit' you out de way."

Claude put on de nightgown
an' Grnnd-rnere's nightcap,
den jomp in de bed
like he ta kin' a nap.

He pull up de covers round
his big ol' green head
an' pretend dat he's Grand-mere
jus' lyin' in bed.

An' sho' 'nuff, right soon
dere's a knock at de door,
an' Claude say, "Come in . . .
What you stay outside fo'?"

An' in walk TeJean
an' Petite Rouge Riding Hood.
An' dey look at dat Grand-mere,
an' she don' look good.

Petite Rouge, she say, "Grand-mere !
You face! It's all green!

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An' you skin got dem bomps,
Now what do dat mean?"

Ol' Claude make a smile,
an' he say, "It's dat flu.
It make me all green wit' dem bomps,
Dat's fo' tru'.

"Why don' you come closer,
'cause I wanna see
all dat good food you mama
done cook fo' po' me."

Petite Rouge Riding Hood
an' den TeJean de cat,
dey take a step closer
from where dey was at.

Petite Rouge, she say, "Grand-mere!
I know you been sick,
but I t'ink mah eyes
be playin' on me a trick.

"You mout' kinda big,
an' you nose kinda long,
an' I got me a feelin'
dat somet'in' bad wrong."

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"I been rubbin' mah nose
wit' dem tissue," say Claude,
"an' mah nose look fonny
'cause I rub it too hard.

"Now come one step closer,"
say Claude kinda sweet,
"'cause I t'inkin' dat maybe
it's 'bout time to eat."

Petite Rouge and TeJean
get up real close.
When Claude smile,
TeJean turn as white as dem ghos'.

Petite Rouge, she say, "Grand-mere!
You teeth big and white!
An' TeJean an' me know
dat somet'in' ain't right."

An' dat's when Claude laugh,
an' he say, "Oh . . . Mais oui!
It ain't right fo' you,
but it sho' right fo' me!"

Claude t'ro off dem sheet.
Petite Rouge shout, *"Aiieee!*

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It's dat gator who wanna
make lonch outta me!"

Claude crawl out de bed
an' den onto de floor.
Den Petite Rouge know she
got some trouble, fo' sho' !

But TeJean de cat, ya'll,
he know what to do.
He smart fo' a cat.
Yeah, you know dat fo' tru'.

When Claude turn his back,
TeJean run to de table
An' jump up on top
jus' as fas' as he able.

He find him de bottle
dat say "Red Hot Sauce."
Den he reach back his arm
an' he give it a toss.

He see Petite Rouge
catch de sauce in her han",
den he pull out dat basket
a piece a' boudin.

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He toss dat boudin
jus' when Claude start to hiss.
TeJean cross his fingers
an' hope she don' miss.

Petite Rouge watch dat boudin
come fly t'roo de air,
den she reach up an' catch it . . .
but guess who right dere?
Dat's right! It was Claude.
Petite Rouge knew one t'ing:
Ol' Claude's mout' ain't open
'cause he like to sing!

She take dat hot sauce
and 'fo' you count to two,
she soak dat boudin wit' dat sauce,
t'roo an t'roo.

She shove dat boudin right
in front a' Claude's nose,
jus' 'bout de same time
Claude done snap his jaws close.

He t'ink he done bite
Petite Rouge Riding Hood,
an', at firs', Claude be t'inkin'

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she taste pretty good.

But den he stop chewin'
an' close bot' his eye,
den sit up and t'ink
maybe he gonna die!

He make dem back flip
'cause dat boudin so hot.
An' de next t'ing you know,
his tail tied in dem knot!

He dance all around.
He don' know what to do.
His mout' feel like fire.
His nose burnin' too.

So into de swamp
wit' his mout' open wide,
Claude jomp in dat water
to cool off inside.

An' den, from dat closet,
Grand-mere, she peek out,
'cause she want to see
what be makin' Claude shout.

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An' when she see Claude
in dat swamp jompin' rouu',
she come out de closet
an' dance up and down.
Den Grand-mere, TeJean,
an' Petite Rouge Riding Hood
be roll' on dat floor
an' dey laugh deyself good.

Den Grand-mere stan' up
an' she dus' off her clothes.
She say, "Hoo! Dat food sho'
smell good to mah nose.

"Now pull up some chair
an' le's take a look
at all a' de good food
you mama done cook."

An' soon, dey all eatin'
dat shrimp etouffee,
boudin, an' gumbo
wit' lotsa file.

An' when dey all t'roo,
Petite Rouge tell Grand-mere,
"Go sit youself down

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in you big rockin' chair."

Grand-mere, she sit down
wit' TeJean on her lap,
an' soon Petite Rouge and
dem all take dem nap.

An' folks in de swamp
say dat sometimes dey see
ol' Claude hangin' roun'
dat ol' stomp of a tree.

"CauseClaude, dat ol' gator,
he finally tool down.
But when he see people now,
he don' come roun'.
Ol' Claude reckon .people
be too hot to eat.
He don' know dat de hot sauce
done made all de heat.

Ol' Claude, hebeen tricked,
so it all worked out good
fo' TeJean, Grand-mere,
an' Petite Rouge Riding Hood!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

In this story, you may find some words that are new to you. Here's what they mean:

- **Adieu**-pronounced "ah DYUH," this word means "good-bye."
- **Boudin**-pronounced "BOO dan," it is a kind of Cajun sausage.
- **Etouffce**-pronounced "ay too FAY," this word literally means "smothered." Food that is prepared in this manner is covered with liquid while it cooks.
- **File**-pronounced "FEE lay," it is a seasoning made of ground sassafras root. Grand-mere-pronounced "grawnd mare," it is the French term for Grandmother.
- Gumbo-pronounced "GUM ho," it is a kind of Cajun soup that includes okra, chicken, sausage, or seafood. The word gumbo is an African Bantu word that means "okra."

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- **Mais oui**-pronounced "may WEE," it is the French term for "yes."
- Pirogue-pronounced "PEE rowg," it is a narrow, flat canoe that is pushed or paddled through the bayou, marsh, or swamp.
- **Si'l vous** plait-pronounced "seal voo PLAY," it is the French term for "If you please."

You can listen to the author read the story in a Cajun dialect at this link:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VKrIiaJ-FzQ
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